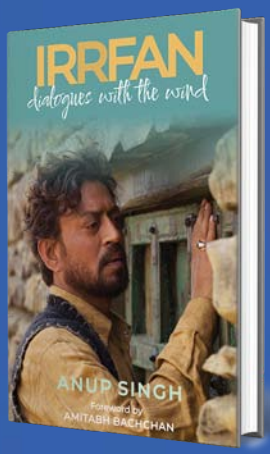
THE OBITUARY IRRFAN DESERVES

ANUP SINGH'S MEMOIR OF HIS RELATIONSHIP WITH IRRFAN KHAN PROVES THAT FOR THE FILMMAKER, THE LEGENDARY ACTOR WAS BOTH COLLEAGUE AND MUSE



IRRFAN
Dialogues with the Wind
by Anup Singh
COPPER COIN
₹**699; 270** pages

Filmmaker Anup Singh remembers it was 4.54 am when his wife Catherine woke him up. His phone had been buzzing repeatedly, disturbing the quiet of their French country residence. Singh recalls grabbing the phone and making his way to the garden. He had received hundreds of messages, telling him about Irrfan's passing. He was still hoping they were rumours, so he texted Irrfan's wife, Sutapa Sikdar, who confirmed the news. Dazed, Singh sat under a cherry tree.

Anup Singh and Irrfan had worked on two films together: *Qissa* (2013) and *The Song of Scorpions* (2017), and were preparing for their third collaboration when Irrfan was diagnosed with a malignant tumour. "There was so much that was left incomplete in terms of our work, our relationship," says Singh. It was almost like Singh couldn't let go of his friend, colleague and muse. He began hearing him everywhere, even in the sound of doors. "Certain images flare in your head, you remember gestures, and I did my best to not remember. It was too painful. I slowly realised there was no escape. And that, perhaps, my friend was talking to me." That's how Singh began working on *Irrfan: Dialogues with the Wind*, a memoir of Singh's working relationship with Irrfan, and a tribute to their shared art and friendship.

When asked about what separated Irrfan from his contemporaries, Singh recounts an incident from the sets of *The Song of Scorpions*. "It was an intense scene. Irrfan had to cross the desert and come close to a large dune. It was a scene of great loss and emotional danger. We were completely focused. Irrfan began doing the scene, but stopped all of a sudden." He called out to his director, and asked him to sniff something he had chanced upon. "It was deer dung!" laughs Singh. Irrfan, he says, was the rare actor who allowed himself to get distracted by elements around him, which gave his work a real-life palpability.

What would Irrfan have thought of the book? "Irrfan was improvisatory, which means he had given up on a fixed notion of image. He lost all of his self-consciousness. By the end, I got the feeling that he was telling me—'Let's work together, let's find out more about ourselves.'"

Irrfan's passing has left a giant void in the industry and in the hearts of his fans. Singh hopes his book can remind them of Irrfan's trademark lilt. "Like every artist of a certain stature, I think Irrfan demanded that we change our established ways of seeing and speaking about what we see. I think he demands that we renew our relationship with ourselves and our universe." ■

–Tatsam Mukherjee

Anup Singh's memoir of Irrfan came about after the filmmaker couldn't stop hearing and sensing the actor everywhere after his death



FRIEND AND MUSE
Anup Singh and Irrfan on the sets of *The Song of Scorpions*